



MANMOHAN
AT AN ELECTION
RALLY IN KOCHI

PTI

Market Liberaliser. Then remember, contrary to the popular myth, the then chairman of the UGC was not his first choice. Instead, it was former RBI governor I.G. Patel. So it was not that Rao turned to the would-be saviour of the marketplace after experiencing an epiphany on the road to South Block. More than a decade later, the phenom called Prime Minister Manmohan Singh would be born out of the melodramatic “No” of a Sonia at her renunciatory best. He came from nowhere to the centrestage as an afterthought.

And Candidate Manmohan was not a spontaneous thought from the Leader. When Candidate Advani became unbearably presidential in his style, Sonia needed a rejoinder and Manmohan was the most effective—and suitable—one available. So there he is, rearing to go for a second act. The gentler, kinder Manmohan has metamorphosed into a an angry—and occasionally argumentative—politician who has even developed a penchant for sound bites that really “hurt”. In his desperate bid to redeem himself from the caricature of “the weakest prime minister”, he has already let the professorial veneer go. The Oxbridge gloves are off and now it is attack-and-retreat. It is a dramatic shift

from the sidelines where he occupied only one-third of the space on his party’s campaign posters.

They tell a story. A story about dynasty and hierarchy. While reviewing the party’s campaign recently, Pranab Mukherjee brought up the example of the opponents: along with posters depicting the trinity of L.K. Advani, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Rajnath Singh, the BJP also had hoardings of its prime ministerial candidate in singular splendour. He wondered if the Congress should also give such a treatment to Manmohan. A resounding silence followed. There would be no Manmohan-alone posters; he would always be in the benevolent company of Sonia. Only Rahul Gandhi, the Future, would be allowed to play it solo on cardboards. An omnipotent Gandhi has for the first time named a non-Gandhi as prime ministerial candidate. It is a family prerogative and Manmohan is indebted. Now the Family has to ensure that it is worth the investment. “Yes we have said that our prime ministerial candidate is Dr Singh but it is Sonia Gandhi who leads the campaign. She is the party president. In earlier cases both the party chief and the prime minister candidate were rolled into one. This time it

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